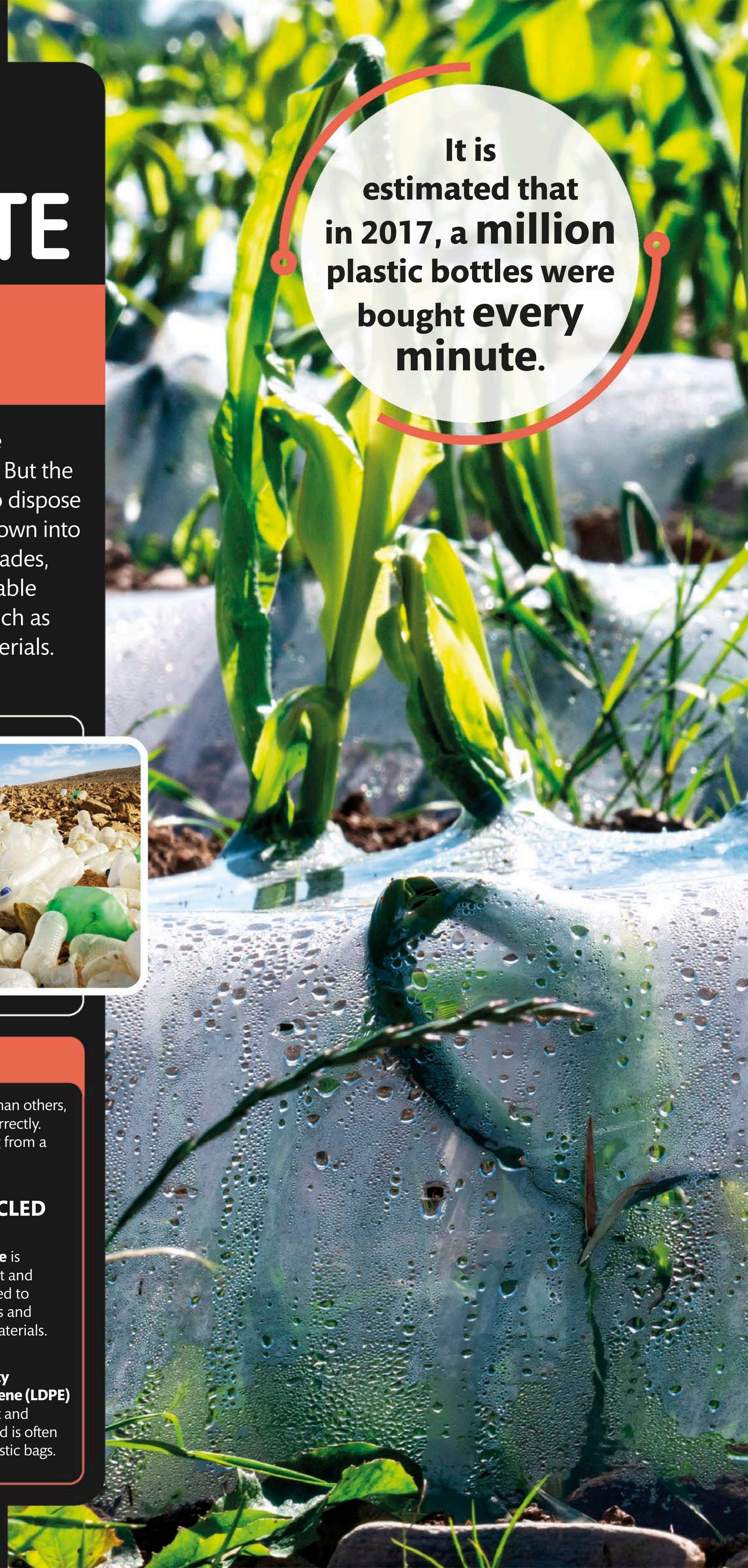
REDUCING PLASTIC WASTE

BIODEGRADABLE MATERIALS

Plastics have many useful properties—they are cheap to produce, lightweight, and hard-wearing. But the durability of plastic is a problem when you want to dispose of it. Plastics are human-made and tend to break down into smaller pieces, polluting the environment for decades, if not longer. Scientists are developing biodegradable plastics, to be easily broken down by microbes such as fungi and bacteria, as well as new alternative materials.



It is estimated that in 2017, a **million** plastic bottles were bought **every minute.**

PROBLEM PLASTIC

Although plastic can be recycled, it is estimated that only 9 percent is. About 12 percent is incinerated and 79 percent is dumped in landfill sites or the ocean. More than 7.9 million tons (7.2 million tonnes) of plastic end up in the ocean each year, polluting the marine environment.

RECYCLING PLASTICS

There are many different types of plastic. Some are more easy to recycle than others, so it is important to know the difference to help you dispose of them correctly. Best of all, avoid using plastics whenever you can—for example, drinking from a reusable water bottle and using paper straws and cups.

EASILY RECYCLED

Polyethylene terephthalate (PET) is a common type of plastic used to make most plastic bottles.

High-density polyethylene (HDPE) is a strong plastic found in jars and shampoo bottles.

LESS EASILY RECYCLED

Polystyrene is lightweight and can be used to make cups and packing materials.

Low-density polyethylene (LDPE) is very soft and flexible and is often used in plastic bags.